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FOR IMMEDIATE RELEASE

Musicians' Enduring Legacy Organization (MELO) to Honor Legendary Drummer Harold Jones with Annual Enduring Legacy Award in NYC

The June 16 event will also feature MELO's traveling museum exhibit showcasing the history of 'The Negro Motorist Green Book'

NEW YORK (May 20, 2026) — The Musicians' Enduring Legacy Organization (MELO) will honor legendary drummer Harold Jones for his extraordinary contributions to music with a one-night-only concert at the Appel Room at Jazz at Lincoln Center's Frederick P. Rose Hall on June 16, 2026.

Presented in the spirit of Juneteenth and Black Music Month, the private evening will bring together industry luminaries, musicians, advocates, and friends for an evening of culinary delights, live musical entertainment, and the presentation of the 2026 **MELO Enduring Legacy Award** to the incomparable Harold Jones. The annual Enduring Legacy Award embodies MELO's mission to preserve and promote the rich musical history that formed the foundation of American popular music.

"This award is about recognizing the legacies and genius of outstanding unsung heroes who have shaped American music," said MELO CEO and founder Josephine Beavers. "Harold Jones is an icon, and we want to let him know how appreciated he is — by us, and by everyone whose life his music has touched."

A master of his craft, Jones rose to prominence as the rhythmic heartbeat of the Count Basie Orchestra and spent decades as Tony Bennett's trusted musical anchor, including helming the drums for Bennett's iconic collaborations with Lady Gaga. Over his storied career, Jones has also performed and recorded alongside Ella Fitzgerald, Sarah Vaughan, Oscar Peterson, and Benny Goodman, earning his place among the most respected musicians in American jazz.

Emmy Award-winning "60 Minutes" correspondent **Bill Whitaker** will host the evening, and live musical performances will be led by the **Ed Vodicka Orchestra**, vocalist **Josephine Beavers**, and honoree **Harold Jones**, with additional special guests to be announced.

The event is produced by **Jordan/Grand Songbook Music & Media**, whose recent productions include the documentary film "The Musician's Green Book: An Enduring Legacy" (PBS, 2023) and an upcoming documentary about Rock & Roll Hall of Fame drummer Earl Palmer. An exhibition, drawn from the film and created by MELO, will be on view during the celebration. This traveling showcase educates on the history of "The Negro Motorist Green Book," a Jim Crow-era essential for African-American motorists from the 1930s to the 1960s. As part of MELO's ongoing mission to bring this exhibition to audiences throughout the country, past installations have included a showing at the Martin Luther King Jr. Memorial Library in Washington, D.C., sponsored by the Smithsonian Institution.

EVENT DETAILS

What: The 2026 MELO Enduring Legacy Award honoring Harold Jones
When: Tuesday, June 16, 2026 - Cocktails 6 p.m., Program 7:45 p.m.
Where: The Appel Room, Jazz at Lincoln Center's Frederick P. Rose Hall - New York City, NY
Presented by: The Musicians' Enduring Legacy Organization nfp (MELO) - melomusic.org
Produced by: Jordan/Grand Songbook Music & Media - grandsongbook.com

The MELO Enduring Legacy Awards are presented by the **Musicians' Enduring Legacy Organization nfp (MELO)**, a 501(c)3 nonprofit committed to educating and inspiring audiences about the enduring contributions of American musicians.

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